

commits suicide when Aeneas is tricked into abandoning her.

After James II was overthrown in 1688, Purcell's creative activities broadened. From 1689, he provided birthday odes for Queen Mary II (see [box](#)). But with the militaristic William III opposed to elaborate church music, he now began to write for a broader middle-class audience: in the published sets of "choyce ayres and songs," in incidental music for plays, and in the "semi-operas" (as the contemporary writer Roger North dubbed them) for the Dorset Garden Theatre, off Fleet Street. Purcell the court composer had morphed into a composer for the commercial stage.

All-sung opera, that dangerously exotic Italian import, was still deemed alien to the "robust" English temperament. The recipe for public success was to take an existing play, fillet it, and stuff it with music, dance, and spectacular scenic effects. These multimedia extravaganzas, involving separate casts of actors, dancers, and singers, present a serious challenge to today's producers and are therefore rarely performed. Yet the four semi-operas—*Dioclesian*, *King Arthur*, *The Fairy-Queen*, and *The Indian Queen*—from Purcell's final years contain some of his most atmospheric and melodically alluring music.